Kazuki Yano

yano.kazuki@dc.tohoku.ac.jp | kazuki-ya.github.io
LinkedIn | Google Scholar

Summary

I am a second-year Ph.D. student at Tohoku University working on large language model pre-training, training dynamics, and efficient model scaling, with recent research on multimodal foundation models and adapting text LLMs to new modalities. I have first-author publications at leading venues including **ICLR 2026**, **INTERSPEECH 2026**, **COLM 2025**, and **NAACL 2025**. I have hands-on experience in end-to-end large-scale model training, including pre-training, post-training, and controlled analysis on high-performance compute clusters.

Education

Tohoku University Sendai, Japan
Ph.D. in Information Science (expected) 2025 – 2028
M.S. in Information Science 2023 – 2025
Supervisor for both degrees: Jun Suzuki

Carnegie Mellon University Oct 2026 – Mar 2027
Visiting Scholar
WAVLab, Language Technologies Institute
Advisor: Shinji Watanabe

Experience

Amazon Japan G.K. Jun 2026 – Sep 2026
Research Fellow

- Developed LLM-based personalized recommendation, including user persona modeling and candidate reranking.

SB Intuitions Nov 2024 – May 2026
Research Intern

- Conducted LLM development on a large compute cluster, spanning pre-training and post-training.

Preferred Networks Inc. Aug 2024 – Mar 2025
Research Intern

- Built synthetic-data pipelines for LLM training; evaluated continued pre-training (CPT) and supervised fine-tuning (SFT).

Rakuten Group, Inc. Jul 2024 – May 2025
Data Scientist (Part-time)

- Studied representation/activation steering for style control via inference-time interventions.

LINE Corporation Aug 2023 – Sep 2023
Research Intern

- Developed an efficient adversarial-prompt optimization method for safety stress-testing aligned dialogue LMs.

Publications

Adapting Text LLMs to Speech via Multimodal Depth Up-Scaling
Kazuki Yano, Jun Suzuki, and Shinji Watanabe
INTERSPEECH 2026 [Paper]

Pre-training LLM without Learning Rate Decay Enhances Supervised Fine-Tuning
Kazuki Yano, Shun Kiyono, Sosuke Kobayashi, Sho Takase, and Jun Suzuki
ICLR 2026 [Paper]

Publications (continued)

TimeMachine-bench: A Benchmark on Evaluating Model's Capability on Repository-level Migration Tasks
Ryo Fujii, Makoto Morishita, **Kazuki Yano**, and Jun Suzuki
EACL 2026 [Paper]

Suppressing Final Layer Hidden State Jumps in Transformer Pretraining
Keigo Shibata, **Kazuki Yano**, Ryosuke Takahashi, Wataru Ikeda, and Jun Suzuki
Findings of EACL 2026 [Paper]

Efficient Construction of Model Family through Progressive Training Using Model Expansion
Kazuki Yano, Sho Takase, Sosuke Kobayashi, Shun Kiyono, and Jun Suzuki
COLM 2025 [Paper]

Layer-wise Importance Analysis of Feed-Forward Networks in Transformer-based Language Models
Wataru Ikeda, **Kazuki Yano**, Ryosuke Takahashi, Jaesung Lee, Keigo Shibata, and Jun Suzuki
COLM 2025 [Paper]

STEP: Staged Parameter-Efficient Pre-training for Large Language Models
Kazuki Yano, Takumi Ito, and Jun Suzuki
NAACL 2025 [Paper]

Document-level Translation with LLM Reranking: Team-J at WMT 2024 General Translation Task
Keito Kudo, Hiroyuki Deguchi, Makoto Morishita, Ryo Fujii, Takumi Ito, Shintaro Ozaki, Koki Natsumi, Kai Sato, **Kazuki Yano**, Ryosuke Takahashi, Subaru Kimura, Tomomasa Hara, Yusuke Sakai, and Jun Suzuki
WMT 2024 [Paper]

STEP: Staged Parameter-Efficient Pre-training for Large Language Models
Kazuki Yano, Takumi Ito, and Jun Suzuki
ACL 2024 Student Research Workshop

Honors and Awards

Outstanding Paper Award 2025
The 31st Annual Meeting of the Association for Natural Language Processing (NLP 2025)
Awarded to top 14 / 765 submissions

BOOST Program for next-generation AI areas (JST) 2025
Broadening Opportunities for Outstanding young researchers and doctoral students in STrategic areas
Research Fellow (subsidized by JST)

Encouragement Award 2025
The 31st Annual Meeting of the Association for Natural Language Processing (NLP 2025)
Awarded to top 20 / 487 eligible submissions

Encouragement Award 2024
The 30th Annual Meeting of the Association for Natural Language Processing (NLP 2024)
Awarded to top 18 / 427 eligible submissions

Academic Service

Reviewer ARR, TMLR, ICML (2026), NeurIPS (2026), ICASSP (2026, 2027), ICLR (2027).

Skills

Tools Python, PyTorch, distributed training, Linux, Git, Slurm, Docker/Singularity

Languages Japanese (native), English (professional working proficiency)